DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Is Torah Study So Powerful?

Derech Hashem 4:2:1-4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 2, paragraphs 1-4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 20 January 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

Part 4 goes through the misvot we regularly do. Chapter 1 divided the service of God into action and study, and action into four kinds: the six constant misvot, daily misvot such as Shahrit, tefillin and Shema, seasonal misvot such as Sukkot, and circumstantial ones. Chapter 2, the subject of this class and the next, is the study of Torah.

Paragraph 1: study leads to action

Torah study is absolutely necessary, because without it you cannot know what to do. That is why the Gemara says that study is great, since it brings to action.

Paragraph 2: more than knowing what to do

But that is not all. Suppose you already knew how to do every misvah properly; what would be the point of further study? And much of Torah will never come to practice: questions in the Gemara that will never arise, the laws of the Beit HaMikdash and the service of the kohanim. If study were only for practice, why learn them?

The Ramhal answers that apart from leading to action, Torah study brings perfection to a person. Beyond all the regular influences God bestows, there is one influence higher than all of them, more precious than anything ever created. "If we can say this, it's a drop of HaKadosh Barukh Hu itself." The Rabbi stressed how careful one must be in speaking like this. God tied this influence into something He created, which He called the Torah. This is what the Zohar means: *Kudsha Berikh Hu veOraita had hu*, God and the Torah are one, since the Torah is the means by which a human being can come to know God as far as possible. "The Torah is the greatest energy that there is."

Speaking and understanding

What does "studying Torah" mean? There are two aspects, "rarely talked about", and the Rabbi wanted them appreciated.

Higayon means uttering, verbalising. People think it means toiling, but the root always means to say something aloud.

Haskalah means intellectual understanding.

God created words, the five books of the Torah and, on a lower level, the books of Neviim and Ketuvim, and tied this influence into them. When a person says the words of these twenty-four books, the influence comes down on him; and when he understands them, it comes down too. Either one works, and both together are better. But looking at the words with no understanding and without saying them achieves nothing. All of this depends on conditions that the Ramhal explains later.

Participants asked about reading an English translation all day. The Rabbi: that gives the aspect of understanding, though not the aspect of uttering the holy text, and either one brings down the influence. Asked about commentaries like Rashi, he said the better question is the status of Mishnah and Gemara, which would come shortly.

A participant asked how Rabbi Shimon bar Yohai could exempt himself from prayer because he was learning. The Rabbi explained that study never exempts a person from performing misvot; you still shake the lulav. Prayer is a specific case: its point is to speak to God, and if a person feels God's presence constantly in his learning, he may not need it. "Prayer is when we speak to God, and Torah is when God speaks to us", as Rabbi Sacks once put it. But this is not recommended for anyone.

Paragraph 3: levels upon levels

There are many levels of this influence, divided among the different ways of engaging with Torah and the different parts of Torah. Reading has one level, understanding another; this part of Torah one level, that part another. The deeper the understanding, the greater the influence: reading, understanding the plain meaning, and understanding the deeper meaning are not the same. But in God's kindness, every Jew can take part, even one who can only read.

A participant asked whether non-Jews who study the Bible gain this. The Rabbi was hesitant. On one hand, the Gemara forbids teaching Torah to non-Jews, because the Torah is a covenant between Israel and God. On the other hand, a non-Jew must learn the seven Noahide laws, and studying the parts of Torah relevant to him, which arguably includes all of Sefer Bereshit, would certainly bring reward, if done for the right reasons.

The Oral Law serves the Written Torah

Now to Mishnah and Gemara. "Unfortunately this is forgotten sometimes, in all the craze about learning Gemara": at the root of everything is the Torah, the five books with Neviim and Ketuvim. The Mishnah and Gemara exist to help us understand the Torah, to engage with its deeper levels. He recalled the joke about the yeshivah student who thinks the Torah is a commentary on the Gemara. The Rabbi's view is that not every passage of Gemara carries the same influence; some passages are stories with useful messages. He said it is sad that people spend so much time on Gemara without knowing Neviim and Ketuvim properly.

Paragraph 4: the whole Torah

Every part of Torah also rectifies some part of the world, so one who wants to serve God properly should cover the whole Torah. He recalled a story about a man who studied only Hagigah all his life: lovely, but not enough. Even if you cannot master everything, "at least get a feel of it", like a traveller with a few hours' stopover who can say he has been to that country: "I've been to Zevahim." Divide your time among all parts of Torah. Do not learn only Gemara, only Tanakh, only halacha or only Kabbalah. What the conditions are for bringing down this influence would follow on Monday.

Summary

- Torah study leads to action, but it also brings perfection in itself.
- God tied His highest influence into the words of the Torah, especially the twenty-four books.
- That influence is released by saying the words and by understanding them, and best by both.
- Mishnah and Gemara serve to explain the Written Torah.
- A person should study every part of Torah, at least enough to "visit" it.

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